

Living bones

Your bones are not lifeless. Packed with blood vessels, nerves, and cells, they can bleed when cut and can grow and repair themselves. Bones appear a few weeks after a baby starts to develop in its mother's womb, and continue growing after birth, through childhood, and into early adulthood.

EARLY SKELETON

Babies are born with more than 300 bones, but these are not fully formed. As the baby grows, some of these bones fuse together to form bigger bones. A baby's skull is flexible to help the mother give birth.

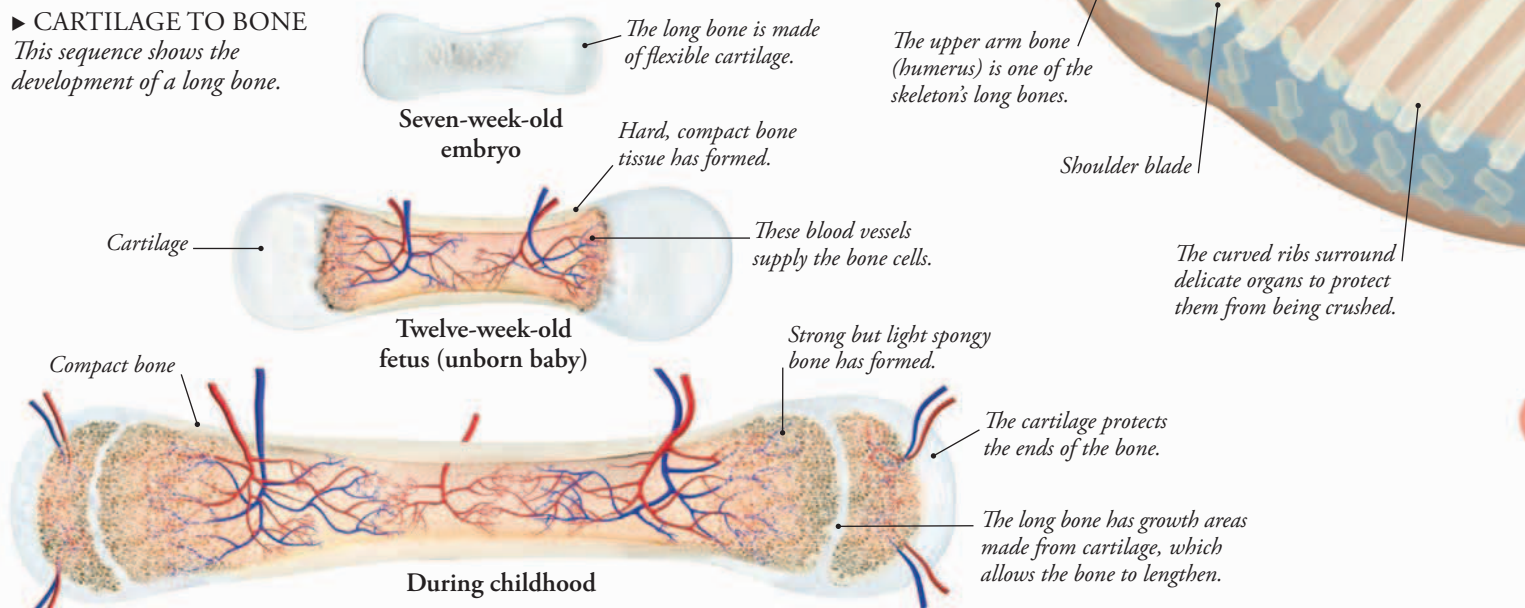
The strong, flat bones of the skull protect the brain.

HOW BONES GROW

When bones first form, they are made of flexible cartilage, like the tissue that supports your ear. As the weeks and years pass, bone cells turn this soft cartilage framework into much harder bone. This process eventually finishes at the age of 20.

► CARTILAGE TO BONE

This sequence shows the development of a long bone.



▼ **IN THE WOMB** By 17 weeks, the bones in this skeleton have grown enough for the unborn baby to make movements.

Bone

Cartilage